CHELSEA FC | TACTICAL DIAGNOSTIC & MIDFIELD RECRUITMENT DOSSIER (2026/27)

Resolving the Double-Pivot Progression Bottleneck and Transition Fragility in Xabi Alonso's 3-4-2-1 / 4-4-2 System

Prepared by the Head of Tactical Analytics & Midfield Recruitment. Sample: opening 7 Premier League fixtures of 2026/27 (Matchweeks 1–7). Recruitment benchmarks: complete 2025/26 league seasons scaled to per-90 values.

1. In-Possession Build-Up: Asymmetric 3-2-4-1 and the Central Box

Chelsea are listed as a 3-4-2-1 (or a 4-2-3-1 on team sheets) but build from the back in an asymmetric 3-2-4-1. Right wing-back Pedro Neto holds high and wide on the last line and behaves like an orthodox touchline winger. The left wing-back or fullback, Pep Chavarría or Jorrel Hato, therefore tucks inside alongside Levi Colwill and Maxence Lacroix to form the back three. The right-sided centre-back, Wesley Fofana or Josh Acheampong, splits toward the right touchline to cover the space behind Neto.

In the middle, the two deeper centre-backs and the double pivot form a 2+2 build-up box. The box exists to draw the opponent's first line of pressure centrally and create a 4v2 or 4v3 overload. From there the ball goes either straight through the half-spaces to the two #10s, Cole Palmer and Morgan Rogers, or out to the wide channels once the opposition block narrows.

2. Out-of-Possession Rest Defence: The Flat 4-4-2 Mid-Block

Without the ball Chelsea settle into a flat 4-4-2. The left fullback (Chavarría or Hato) drops into a back four with Colwill, Lacroix and Fofana or Acheampong. Rogers drops to left midfield and Neto to right midfield, forming the second line of four with the central double pivot. Palmer and the striker, João Pedro or Danny Welbeck, stay high as the front two and press the opposition centre-backs.

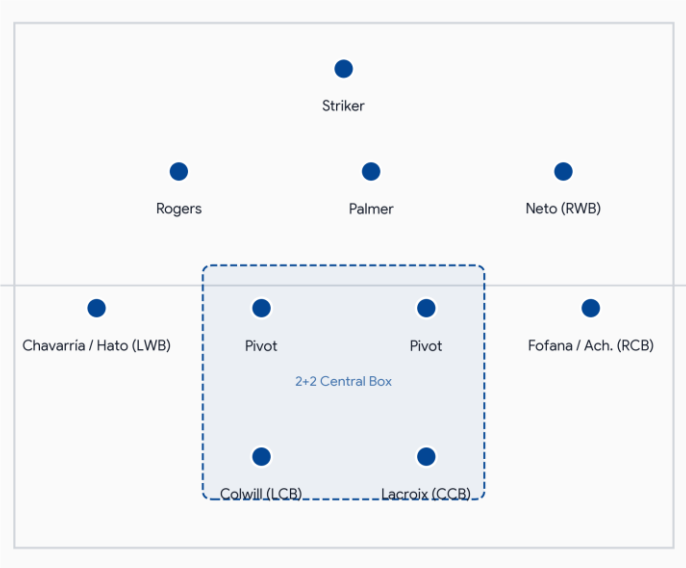


Diagram 1. In possession: asymmetric 2-4-3-1 (with 2+2 central box)



Diagram 2. Out of possession: flat 4-4-2 mid-block

3. The Structural Breakdown

The two-phase system places heavy physical and technical demands on the two central midfielders. In possession they must receive on the half-turn under 360-degree pressure at the top of the build-up box and break lines vertically. Out of possession, when Neto and Rogers are caught high after a turnover, the two pivots must cover the full width of the 4-4-2 midfield line and sprint out to protect the wide centre-back channels.

Across the opening 7 league fixtures of 2026/27, none of Chelsea's four internal pivot options (Jordan Henderson, Moisés Caicedo, Roméo Lavia, Valentín Barco) has sustained both phases at the same time. The rest of this dossier tests that claim in four steps: the in-possession diagnosis (page 2), the out-of-possession diagnosis (page 3), the recruitment benchmark and pairing model (pages 4 and 5), and the contract execution plan (page 6).

Headline figures carried through the dossier

Measure	Value	Where it appears
Buildup completion, with vs without Henderson	83.8% vs 78.2%	Page 2
Final third entries per game, with vs without Henderson	49.0 vs 53.3	Page 2
Goals conceded per game, Caicedo starting vs not starting	0.50 vs 2.40	Page 3
Henderson tackles attempted per 90 at 50.0% win rate	0.59	Page 3
Top double-pivot pairing, Caicedo + Stiller (Total Tactical Fit)	90.4	Page 5
Stiller release clause against a €46.0M valuation	€36.5M	Page 6

STEP 1 — In-Possession Diagnosis: The Central Progression Void

The first seven fixtures split into two midfield states. Chelsea's numbers on the ball differ sharply between them, and neither state produces both secure retention and forward penetration.

Without Henderson (4 matches: Fulham 2-3 W, Brighton 4-3 W, Arsenal 2-1 L, Hull City 2-2 D). Lavia partnered makeshift pivots Reece James or Malo Gusto, and first-phase build-up under a high press was unreliable. Possession averaged 44.5%, buildup completion 78.2% and accurate passes 323.5 per match. Against Brighton's aggressive press (6.2 PPDA), buildup completion fell to 63.1% on 25.9% possession, with 155 accurate passes in 90 minutes.

With Henderson (3 matches: Brentford 3-0 L, Bournemouth 5-1 W, Everton 0-2 W). The 36-year-old stabilised first-phase retention. Buildup completion rose to 83.8% (+5.6), possession to 53.8% (+9.3) and accurate passes to 415.3 per game. Penetration slowed: final third entries fell from 53.3 to 49.0 per game (-4.3), deep entries from 14.5 to 10.7 (-3.8), and open-play expected threat (xT) from 1.18 to 0.93.

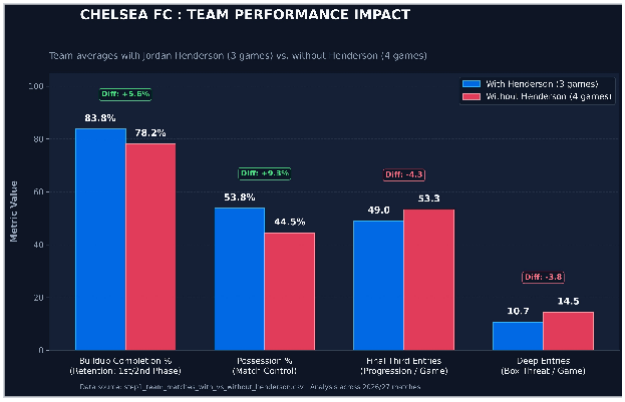


Figure 1. Team performance with Henderson (3 matches) and without (4 matches), 2026/27.

Per-90 squad progression (Markstats Top-200 dataset, N=14 qualified players)

- **Henderson, safe recycling.** He leads Chelsea in pass volume at 64.75 per 90 (82.6% completion; 94.4% to 96.7% accuracy in his own half across three starts). He logs 2.81 progressive passes per 90 (PPAS), 0.65 progressive carries per 90 (PCRY) and 0.00 passes into the penalty box per 90 (PBX). Against Bournemouth he recorded no progressive carries and 14.9 metres of total ball progression in 90 minutes. At 0.65 PCRY he cannot carry past a marker, so opponents can man-mark him without fear of being beaten on the dribble.
- **Lavia, low volume.** 34.37 passes per 90 (85.6%), 1.71 PPAS and 0.53 PCRY per 90, in the bottom-left Deep Circulation quadrant.
- **Centre-backs forced to progress.** Because the pivot does not break lines, Fofana (3.83 PPAS, 1.45 PCRY per 90), James (4.14 PPAS, 0.77 PCRY) and Colwill (2.98 PPAS, 0.77 PCRY) out-progress the central midfielders.
- **Barco exclusion.** Barco (116 minutes over three appearances) did not meet the minutes threshold for the 14-player season table.

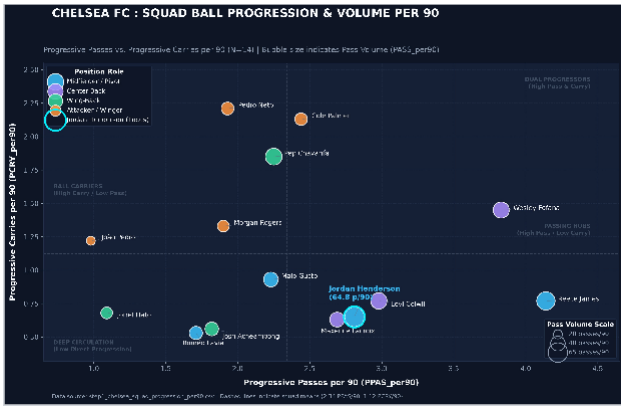


Figure 2. Progressive passes against progressive carries per 90; bubble size is pass volume per 90.

Passing network: Brentford (with Henderson) against Hull City (without)

Against Brentford (3-4-2-1), Henderson (#14, 65 touches) circulated through Lacroix (#5, 13 passes), Fofana (#3, 10) and Chavarría (#29, 11), while Colwill (#6) fed Chavarría (16 passes) and Chavarría fed Rogers (#17, 14). Palmer (#10, 39 touches) and Welbeck (#18, 21 touches) had no passing link of five or more passes from the double pivot. Against Hull City (4-2-3-1), play collapsed into a right-flank perimeter loop: Lavia (#45), James (#24, 12 passes), Fofana (#3, 14), Gusto (#27, 18) and Neto (#7, 16). Palmer finished on 28 touches with no high-volume connection.

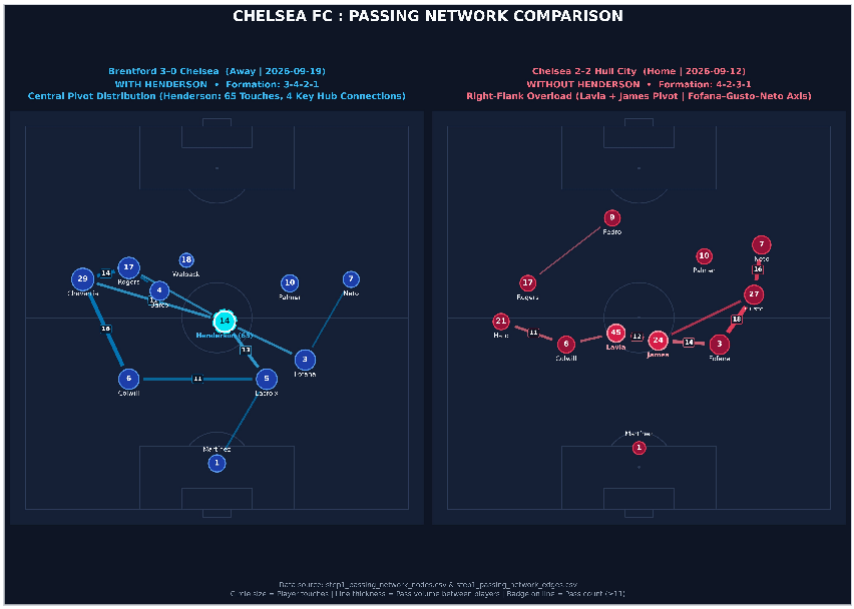


Figure 3. Passing networks, Brentford 3-0 Chelsea (with Henderson) and Chelsea 2-2 Hull City (without).

STEP 2 — Out-of-Possession Diagnosis: The "Caicedo Cliff" and Wide Centre-Back Isolation

The midfield availability problem shows up directly in how the 4-4-2 block and the wide channels defend.

1. Pivot availability and stamina, Matchweeks 1–7

- **Caicedo.** Missed Matchweek 1 (Fulham). Came on at 68′ in Matchweek 2 (Brighton) and was injured 14 minutes later at 82′ (5.7 rating). Missed Matchweeks 3 (Arsenal), 4 (Hull) and 5 (Brentford). Returned for Matchweek 6 (Bournemouth, 72 minutes, 8.0) and Matchweek 7 (Everton, 90 minutes, 6.9).
- **Lavia, a 70-minute ceiling.** Started Matchweeks 1–4 and left before the 70th minute each time: 65′ against Fulham (booked at 12′, 5.9), 68′ against Brighton (7.5), 60′ against Arsenal (6.5) and 69′ against Hull (6.5). He did not feature against Brentford and made cameos of 18′ and 1′ against Bournemouth and Everton.
- **Makeshift cover.** Alonso used fullbacks James (90′ in Matchweeks 1, 3 and 4) and Gusto (90′ in Matchweek 2) in the pivot, then Henderson (three consecutive 90-minute starts in Matchweeks 5–7) and Barco (8′ against Brighton, 21′ against Hull, an 87′ start at Brentford).



Figure 4. Double-pivot availability and match ratings, Matchweeks 1–7.

2. The Caicedo Cliff across starting pivot pairings

Starting pivot (games)	Goals conc. / game	Opp. xG (NPxG)	Opp. shots	Opp. box touches	Dangerous poss. lost
Henderson + Caicedo (2: Bournemouth, Everton)	0.50	0.90 (0.86)	7.5	19.0	17.5
Lavia + James/Gusto (4: Fulham, Brighton, Arsenal, Hull)	2.25	1.54 (1.43)	14.75	28.8	22.3
Henderson + Barco (1: Brentford)	3.00	2.55 (2.10)	13	24.0	13.0

The Lavia pairing peaked at 27 dangerous possessions lost against both Fulham and Hull. At Brentford, Chelsea conceded four big chances from 13 Brentford shots; Henderson (one tackle, no interceptions in 90 minutes) and Barco could not stop central counter-attacks. Grouped by whether Caicedo started, the five games without him averaged 2.40 goals conceded, 1.74 opponent xG and 14.4 opponent shots. The two games with him averaged 0.50, 0.90 and 7.5: goals conceded rise nearly fivefold, opponent xG nearly doubles and opponent shots double.

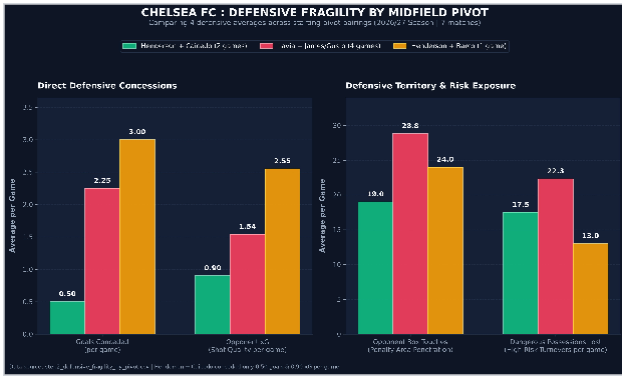


Figure 5. Defensive averages by starting pivot pairing, 2026/27 (7 matches).

3. Wide centre-back isolation in the channels

When opponents bypass the pivot they attack the space behind Neto and Chavarría, so the wide centre-backs and channel defenders carry the heaviest tackling load in the squad.

- **Acheampong (wide CB / RWB):** 3.56 tackles attempted per 90 (TKLA) at a 77.8% win rate (TKL%), first in the squad.
- **Hato (wide CB / LWB):** 2.42 TKLA per 90 at 80.0%.
- **Fofana (right wide CB):** 2.19 TKLA per 90 at 87.5%, plus 1.37 high defensive actions per 90.
- **Henderson:** 0.59 TKLA per 90 at 50.0%, last in the squad. **James:** 0.84 at 66.7%. Lavia is an efficient 1v1 tackler (2.33 per 90 at 87.5%), but his match fitness leaves the wide centre-backs exposed.

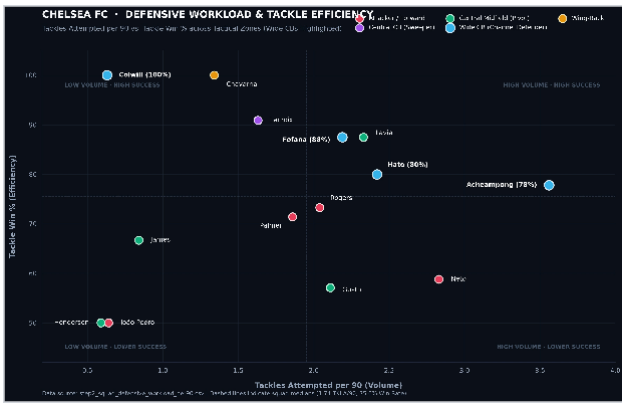


Figure 6. Tackles attempted per 90 against tackle win rate; wide centre-backs highlighted.

STEP 3 (PART A) — The 2025/26 Per-90 Benchmark and the Constructor Upgrade

Methodology

Henderson's 2026/27 sample is three matches and 270 minutes. Set against full-season recruitment targets, a sample that small would distort the comparison. The baseline therefore uses the complete 2025/26 league season for all four Chelsea pivots (Caicedo, Henderson, Lavia, Barco) and all five European targets (Angelo Stiller, Chema Andrés, Alex Scott, Manu Koné, Jack Hinshelwood). Every per-game metric is scaled to a per-90 standard: Per Game × 90 ÷ (Total Minutes ÷ Appearances).

Player (2025/26 club)	Age	Mins (90s)	Acc. passes /90 (%)	Opp. half passes /90 (%)	Key passes /90 (xA/90)	Tkl + Int /90	Balls recov. /90	Ground duel win %	Sprints /90 (top speed)	Turnovers /100 touches	Construct Index	Destruct Index	Overall Fit
Moisés Caicedo (Chelsea)	24	2,900 (32.2)	53.56 (90%)	25.81 (86%)	1.02 (0.07)	**4.71**	5.53	58.0%	12.2 (35.1 km/h)	10.3	65.7	**76.9**	**75.6**
Angelo Stiller (Stuttgart)	25	2,750 (30.6)	**67.21** (89%)	**40.17** (86%)	**1.78** (**0.24**)	2.56	5.23	**63.0%**	7.8 (32.9 km/h)	15.1	**89.1**	51.4	**74.4**
Chema Andrés (Stuttgart)	21	1,377 (15.3)	51.80 (87%)	32.84 (85%)	0.98 (0.08)	**4.08**	5.23	57.0%	12.4 (34.8 km/h)	11.5	66.4	**74.5**	**67.3**
Valentín Barco (Strasbourg)	22	2,220 (24.7)	54.29 (85%)	24.85 (78%)	1.64 (0.22)	3.18	5.14	58.0%	17.6 (34.2 km/h)	19.2	52.5	57.9	58.8
Manu Koné (AS Roma)	25	2,459 (27.3)	45.32 (**90%**)	28.55 (**89%**)	0.96 (0.08)	2.44	5.20	51.0%	9.9 (30.4 km/h)	13.5	62.6	41.6	57.5
Roméo Lavia (Chelsea)	22	377 (4.2)	62.74 (**91%**)	33.80 (**91%**)	0.23 (0.01)	3.16	4.87	55.0%	11.5 (33.9 km/h)	**8.2**	81.0	47.5	56.6
Alex Scott (Bournemouth)	23	2,856 (31.7)	37.08 (82%)	18.89 (78%)	0.93 (0.09)	**3.85**	**6.41**	51.0%	**20.3** (34.7 km/h)	20.1	26.9	**70.9**	56.6
Jordan Henderson (Brentford)	36	1,929 (21.4)	42.10 (78%)	20.75 (67%)	1.19 (0.11)	2.24	4.63	45.0%	13.6 (34.4 km/h)	20.9	21.0	33.8	33.6
Jack Hinshelwood (Brighton)	21	1,758 (19.5)	26.68 (82%)	14.51 (78%)	0.83 (0.12)	1.25	3.46	37.0%	16.7 (**35.4 km/h**)	19.2	17.1	16.3	23.6

Table 1. Nine-player 2025/26 per-90 master comparison. Bold marks the best or near-best value in each column.

Primary constructor target: Angelo Stiller (VfB Stuttgart)

- **Henderson's 2025/26 baseline.** Over 1,929 Premier League minutes Henderson completed 78% of his passes overall and 67% in the opposition half. He turned the ball over 20.9 times per 100 touches and won 45.0% of ground duels.
- **Why Stiller (89.1 Construct Index).** Over 2,750 Bundesliga minutes (4,252 across 52 matches in all competitions) Stiller averaged 92.13 touches, 67.21 accurate passes (89%) and 40.17 accurate opposition-half passes at 86% per 90. His forward passing volume is close to double Henderson's 20.75.
- **Reaching Palmer.** Stiller produced 7.46 xA, 10 big chances created and 1.78 key passes per 90. He is left-footed (183 cm), so on the left of Alonso's build-up box he opens inside-out passing lanes to Palmer and Rogers in the half-spaces.
- **Defensive floor.** He wins 63.0% of ground duels (3.45 per 90), records 2.56 tackles plus interceptions and 5.23 ball recoveries per 90, covers 10.9 km per 90, and had no errors leading to a shot or goal in 34 league appearances.

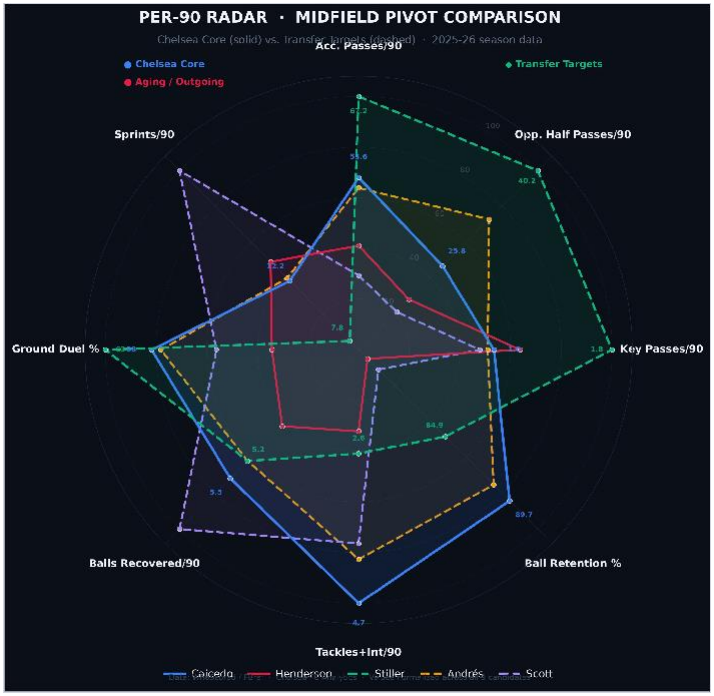


Figure 7. Per-90 radar: Chelsea core (solid) against transfer targets (dashed), 2025/26 data.

STEP 3 (PART B) — Double-Pivot Synergy Matrix and Destructor Filtering

Methodology: permutations and combinations

With Henderson ageing out, Chelsea's internal core is Caicedo, Lavia and Barco. The model scored all C(9,2) = 36 double-pivot pairings and all C(5,2) = 10 two-player recruitment packages across four weighted scenarios:

1. Starting XI synergy alongside Caicedo (35% weight).
2. The two new signings partnering each other when Caicedo is injured or rested (30%).
3. Best pairing alongside Barco (20%).
4. Best pairing alongside Lavia (15%).

Pairings gain synergy adjustments for combining an elite constructor (Construct Index of 65 or more) with an elite destructor (Destruct Index of 68 or more), for left-foot and right-foot angle diversity (R+L) in the build-up box, and for aerial height of 183 cm or more. They are penalised when combined turnovers exceed 18.0 per 100 touches.

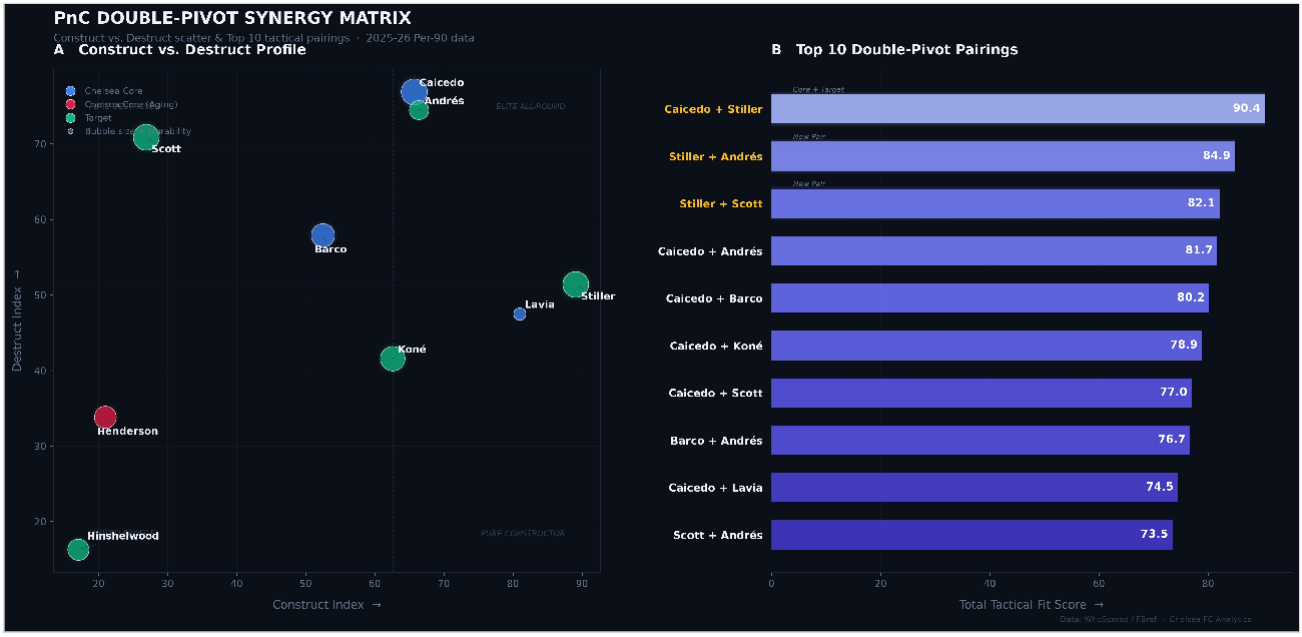


Figure 8. Construct against Destruct profile (A) and the ten highest-scoring double-pivot pairings (B), 2025/26 per-90 data.

Top pairings and target filtering

1. **Best overall pairing: Caicedo + Stiller (90.4 Total Tactical Fit).** Combined output is 120.77 accurate passes per 90 (89.5%), 65.98 opposition-half passes, 7.27 tackles plus interceptions, 10.76 ball recoveries and a 60.5% ground duel win rate, with R+L foot balance.

2. **Best pairing without Caicedo: Stiller + Chema Andrés (84.9 Fit Score; top transfer package at 83.1 Squad Resilience).** Andrés (21, 190 cm, right-footed) was Stiller's midfield partner at VfB Stuttgart in 2025/26 before moving to Brighton. Per 90 he profiles as Caicedo's statistical twin (66.4 Construct Index, 74.5 Destruct Index): 4.08 tackles plus interceptions, 5.23 recoveries, 51.80 accurate passes (87%), 11.3 km covered, a 34.8 km/h top speed, 0.33 times dribbled past and 11.5 turnovers per 100 touches. He is also the highest-scoring partner for Barco (76.7 Fit Score, offsetting Barco's 172 cm height and 19.2 turnovers per 100 touches) and for Lavia (71.0).

3. **Second transfer package and immediate Premier League destructor: Stiller + Alex Scott (82.1 Pair Score; 81.0 Squad Resilience).** Brighton signed Andrés in July 2026 on a long-term deal, which makes Scott (23, Bournemouth) the co-primary, Premier League-tested destructor (70.9 Destruct Index; 100.0 Durability Index over 2,856 league minutes). Scott leads all candidates in sprints (20.3) and ball recoveries (6.41) per 90, and adds 3.85 tackles plus interceptions, 11.0 km and a 34.7 km/h recovery speed. That is the lateral range needed to sprint out and protect the wide centre-backs in the 4-4-2 block. His passing is weaker (82% overall, 78% in the opposition half), but alongside Stiller the pair combine for 104.29 passes per 90, which covers the gap.

4. **Formal eliminations.**

- **Manu Koné (AS Roma, €56M; 57.5 Overall Fit).** Press-resistant retention (90% pass accuracy, 89% in the opposition half, 1.27 dribbles per 90 at 62%), but he lacks the defensive volume (2.44 tackles plus interceptions per 90) and recovery speed (30.4 km/h top speed, 9.9 sprints per 90) to defend wide channels in a 4-4-2. He also costs €56M and carries a recent thigh injury.
- **Jack Hinshelwood (Brighton, €24M; 23.6 Overall Fit).** High top speed (35.4 km/h) and a box-crashing threat (4.82 xG), but an off-ball runner by profile (26.68 accurate passes per 90) who loses central duels (1.25 tackles plus interceptions per 90, 37.0% ground duel win rate).

STEP 4 — Boardroom Execution, Contract Feasibility and Final Verdict

The figures below use verified 2026/27 Capology contract data. They test whether the two-player acquisition fits within PSR/FFP amortisation and the wage bill.

Target	Current club	Age	Contract expiry (yrs left)	Market value / release clause	Gross weekly wage	Gross annual base (+ bonus)	Remaining contract liability	Acquisition role
Angelo Stiller	VfB Stuttgart	25	Jun 30, 2028 (2 yrs)	€46.0M value / **€36.5M release clause**	**€87,115 / wk** (~£73.8k)	**€4,530,000 / yr** (+ €1.13M bonus)	€9,060,000	**Primary Constructor (#1 Sign)**
Alex Scott	Bournemouth	23	Jun 30, 2028 (2 yrs)	**€29.0M value** (no clause)	**£50,000 / wk** (~€59.0k)	**£2,600,000 / yr** (+ £780k bonus)	£5,200,000	**Co-Primary Destructor (Option A)**
Chema Andrés	Brighton	21	Jun 30, 2031 (5 yrs)	**€23.0M value** (no clause)	**£40,000 / wk** (~€47.2k)	**£2,080,000 / yr** (+ £624k bonus)	£10,400,000	**High-Upside Destructor (Option B)**

Table 2. Contract and wage structure of the three targets.

1. The Stiller release clause: €36.5M against a €46.0M valuation

Stiller has two years left on his Stuttgart contract (signed January 28, 2025; expires June 30, 2028) and a verified €36,500,000 release clause. That is €9.5M below his €46.0M valuation. His fixed base salary is €87,115 per week (€4.53M a year, €5.66M with bonuses). A minor early-season injury limited him to 7 Bundesliga appearances (572 minutes) at the start of 2026/27, so Chelsea can move early to trigger or structure the clause and place him in Cobham's incentive-based wage tier of roughly £110k–£120k per week.

2. The destructor decision: Alex Scott or Chema Andrés

Scott is the immediate-window option (package cost €65.5M with the Stiller clause). He has two years left at Bournemouth (expires June 30, 2028; signed August 18, 2023) on £50,000 per week (£2.60M a year base, £5.2M remaining) and has signed no extension since arrival. With 24 months left, Chelsea hold leverage to buy a 23-year-old homegrown England international for roughly €29M–€35M.

Andrés is the strategic alternative and long-term target (package cost €59.5M–€69.0M). His £40,000 per week (£2.08M a year base) is easy to absorb. He signed a five-year Brighton contract on September 1, 2026 (expires June 30, 2031; £10.4M remaining gross salary), so Brighton hold the contract leverage. Chelsea should test whether Brighton will entertain a structured deal and, if not, move to Scott without delay.

3. Five-year amortisation and the squad depth blueprint

Stiller (€36.5M clause) plus Scott (€29M–€35M) is a combined outlay of about €65.5M–€71.5M. Over standard five-year amortisation that is roughly €13.1M–€14.3M a year on the books for two starters aged 23 and 25, with combined base wages under €11M a year.

Final five-man midfield depth chart for Xabi Alonso

Role	Player	Rotation and deployment
Primary box constructor	**Angelo Stiller**	Rotated with Lavia on a managed 60-minute load
Primary 4-4-2 channel destructor	**Moisés Caicedo**	Rotated with Alex Scott or Chema Andrés
Tactical hybrid, LWB / LCM utility	**Valentín Barco**	Deployed only alongside Caicedo, Scott or Andrés
Phased out	**Jordan Henderson**	Moves to a non-starting dressing-room and closing role

Final verdict

The evidence points one way. Chelsea's defensive record changes with who starts beside the pivot (0.50 goals conceded per game with Caicedo, 2.40 without), and the possession record changes with Henderson (83.8% buildup completion with him, but 49.0 final third entries against 53.3 without). The 2025/26 benchmark gives Chelsea a constructor in Stiller (89.1 Construct Index) and a destructor in Scott (70.9 Destruct Index) at a combined €65.5M–€71.5M. Stiller's release clause fixes the largest cost, and Scott's remaining 24 months give Chelsea the leverage on the second. Recommended sequence: trigger or structure the Stiller clause first, open talks for Scott in the same window, and treat Andrés as the fallback only if Brighton engage.